Ricardo Caballero Pascual

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Professional Summary

Senior Game & Narrative Designer with +8 years of experience developing narrative-driven titles for original IPs and major franchises (TMNT, PAW Patrol, etc.).

Specialized in bridging the gap between creative storytelling and technical implementation, with a strong focus on prototyping and systemic design. Proven track record of delivering high-quality results under demanding production constraints, managing world-renowned licenses with a focus on brand integrity, player agency, and efficient resource optimization.

Experience

LEVEL/NARRATIVE DESIGNER & SR. GAME DESIGNER
OUTRIGHT GAMES LTD. (AHEARTFULOFGAMES S.L.), MADRID | 2023 - 2025

- **High-Stakes R&D & Prototyping:** Selected for an internal "Strike Team" to develop playable prototypes and narrative/quest design concepts for Tier-1 Global Entertainment IPs. Authored high-fidelity narrative proposals for a major Sci-Fi franchise, achieving internal creative alignment and ensuring strict adherence to world-building standards and brand integrity for world-renowned licensors.
- **Narrative Design (TMNT: Mutants Unleashed):** Spearheaded narrative cutscenes & dialogues implementation for a 12+ hour campaign. Successfully translated the IP's cinematic vision into gameplay systems, ensuring a seamless narrative experience aligned with the franchise mood and themes.
- **Mechanical Overhaul & Game Feel (Ironskins):** Directed the restructuring of core mechanics to elevate game feel and player retention. Spearheaded a critical systemic overhaul to align the final product with market quality expectations, optimizing encounter design and economy balancing under demanding production constraints.
- **Level Design & Mission Polishing:** Executed high-level mission polishing and encounter design, focusing on player flow, pacing, and environmental storytelling to enhance the overall user experience.
- **Mentorship & Workflow Optimization:** Established design workflows and methodologies for the team, providing mentorship to other team members on Level Design best practices and systemic narrative integration.

GAME DESIGNER
DRAKHAR STUDIO S.L., SANTA CRUZ DE TENERIFE | 2020 - 2023

- **Design Ownership (Cry Babies Magic Tears: The Big Game):** Acted as the primary stakeholder for all design pillars, encompassing Level, Narrative, and Quest Design. Authored the complete game script and served as the main point of contact for programming, art, and animation teams to ensure IP consistency.
- **Licensor Management & Advocacy:** Defended design proposals to global licensors, providing technical and creative documentation to secure final approvals. Managed the end-to-end design pipeline for 'Cry Babies Magic Tears: The Big Game', resulting in high praise from the community for its accessibility and IP fidelity, successfully translating the animated series' essence into a functional game pipeline for preschool audiences.
- **Scope & Production Management:** Following the departure of the studio's producer, assumed additional responsibilities in production tracking. Developed and managed estimation spreadsheets (Excels) and delivery timelines, ensuring project milestones were met under high-pressure conditions.
- **R&D & Open World Prototyping:** Co-led the development of an unannounced fantasy 3D open-world prototype. Established the foundational world building via a comprehensive Narrative Design Document (NDD), structured quest formats, and designed initial levels with a focus on progression and backtracking using optimized resources.
- **Level & Puzzle Design (PAW Patrol / Hotel Transylvania):** Co-led level and puzzle design for 'PAW Patrol The Movie: Adventure City Calls' and 'Hotel Transylvania: Scary-Tale Adventures'. Owned the iteration process from initial greybox blockouts to final polish, ensuring gameplay balanced challenge with franchise-appropriate pacing.
- **Narrative Systems & Funding (One Night - VR):** Redesigned the branching narrative for a Lovecraftian VR experience, implementing player agency while optimizing the scope for commercial viability. Authored the documentation used to secure European Union (EU) funding.
- **Mentorship & Team Growth:** Performed the onboarding and management of interns and new design hires. Provided continuous mentorship and defined workflows to elevate studio standards, project goals, and high-quality deliverables.

NARRATIVE & QUEST DESIGNER
NULL REFERENCE STUDIO, MADRID | 2019 - 2020

- **Award-Winning Narrative/Quest Design (Burn Me Twice):** Spearheaded the narrative architecture and quest design, earning the 'Tell Me a Story' Award at IndieDevDay 2020. Authored the complete game script, including branching dialogue and all in-game lore, balancing a lighthearted yet dark tone inspired by Terry Pratchett's works.
- **Systemic World & NPC Design:** Co-designed and prototyped a complex Cyclical Narrative System using Twine to map logic branches and NPC behavioral routines. Developed the systemic framework for reactive world-building, ensuring 10-minute AI patterns supported both investigation mechanics and story progression.
- **Pipeline Optimization:** Established new Narrative Design pipelines and documentation standards to accelerate the development of gameplay chapters, significantly reducing the iteration time between writing and implementation. This allowed us to finish the game within 1 year delivering 3 full-playable chapters.
- **Localization Management:** Managed and mentored an external translator for the English version of the game. Helped establishing the necessary localization workflows and quality standards to allow for autonomous translation while maintaining narrative tone and consistency without constant supervision.
- **UX & Narrative Synergy:** Collaborated closely with the Art Department to align typography and UI elements with the game's unique narrative tone, ensuring visual consistency across all text-heavy investigation sequences.

NARRATIVE DESIGNER
BLACK SORROWS TEAM, MADRID | 2016 - 2018

- **Concept Development & Narrative Systems:** Defined the original game concept for Black Sorrows, a VR horror experience centered on deep-sea submarine exploration. Designed scalable narrative systems and core gameplay loops focused on player immersion and atmospheric tension.
- **UX & Horror Research:** Helped developing a narrative framework aimed at studying the psychological effects of fear and isolation in Virtual Reality. Implemented pacing strategies and environmental storytelling to maximize emotional impact.
- **Exhibitions & Public Showcasing:** Represented the project at major industry events, including ESVR (Spain Virtual Reality) and Madrid Gaming Experience 2018, managing live demos and gathering player feedback.
- **Game Design & VFX Support:** Contributed to the overall game design and VFX implementation, ensuring a cohesive synergy between visual feedback, pacing, and the high-immersion requirements of VR platforms.

Education

2016 – 2020 Official Bachelor Degree in Game Design | University of Technology, Arts and Design (U-TAD)

2024 - Current Law Degree | National Distance Education University (UNED)

Core Competencies

SKILLS

- Narrative Systems Design & Cinematic Design
- IP Management & Brand Integrity
- Level & Quest Design
- Economy & Balance
- Combat & Game Feel
- Rapid Prototyping
- UX Research for VR
- Localization Pipeline
- Strategic Ownership
- Stakeholder Communication
- Creative Writing

TOOLS & ENGINES

- Unity
- Unreal Engine 4 & 5
- C# & Blueprints
- Blender
- Photoshop, Illustrator & Premiere
- Notion
- Office Suite
- Jira & Trello
- Sourcetree · Plastic SCM
- HTML · CSS
- Twine

KEY ACHIEVEMENTS

- IndieDevDay 2020 award – Tell Me a Story
- Fun&Serious 2020 award – BBK New Talents
- GWDC 2020 Awards - Hobby Game of the Year

LANGUAGES

- English — Advanced (C1)
- Japanese — Beginner (N5)
- Spanish — Native speaker